

Tabloid TECH

People And Events That Grabbed Headlines—For Better Or For Worse

What a novel idea!

The way people go around sending text messages, it was not going to be long before literature was available on SMS. That day has finally arrived. A novel by a Chinese author, Qian Fuchang, is now available as a series of SMSes. The novel is called *Outside the Fortress Besieged*, and has been described as “a steamy tale of adulterous love”. For those who lv rdng novels lk ths,



Can you SMS that novel to me?

Fuchang's *Fortress* will have 60 chapters of 70 characters each. One small step for SMS, a giant leap for literature.

Sovereignty? Never heard of it!



“Sovereignty means...you are given sovereignty”

Along, really long time ago, the Americans made a movie called *The Gods Must Be Crazy* dedicated to the Bush People in Africa's Kalahari Desert. Were they seers? Because the Gods were definitely crazy when George Bush stood in line when they were doling out smarts.

Democracy Now (democracynow.org) has captured audio and video feeds of one more for the Bushism archives in which a reporter is seen asking Dubya: “Mr President, you have been a governor and a president. So you have unique experience looking at tribal sovereignty from two directions. What do you think it means in the 21st century?” The answer: “Yeah, tribal sovereignty means—it's sovereign. You have been given sovereignty, and you are viewed as a sovereign entity.”

God save America! Not from al-Qaeda, but from their own President.

Crippleware for sale

Bill Gates said earlier this year that hardware would be almost free.

But this week, Microsoft launched the ‘Windows XP Starter Edition’ for \$36. More powerful? Nah. The announcement reads, “Users can have up to three programs and three windows per program running concurrently. Further simplification of the operating system includes the display resolution set to 800 x 600 maximum and no support for PC-to-PC home networking, sharing printers across a network or more advanced features such as the ability to establish multiple user accounts on a single PC.”

A lot less than the full-price version, but a lot more than a pirated version. And, a lot more than the free version—the one you “borrowed” from a friend.

The Starter Edition was originally Microsoft's response to Thailand's government-initiated Linux PC project. Now, there's a lot of politics behind it, and Microsoft is doing this to win over Linux users and strike deals with governments. But we have our questions: is there a home user who would prefer this crippleware over the “free licensed version”?

Time to disappear

It's unfortunate. Just when we had SETI@Home, and were hoping to discover aliens and, perhaps, be discovered by them, comes the bad news. Scientist Frank Drake told a SETI workshop at Harvard that “the Earth is going to disappear” very soon, for aliens.

It turns out that the radio signals broadcast by traditional TV antennas are, for aliens, the



Waiting for the aliens

strongest evidence of our existence on this planet.

If we are to have any hope of being discovered by aliens, SETI or someone else will have to start broadcasting radio waves into space, to advertise our presence here—at taxpayers' expense, of course.

Drake laments that most broadcasts now are on cable, and besides, satellites that relay TV do so with unforgiving accuracy, allowing little or no electricity to escape into space.

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